

By Dilip Bobb

Last year, we introduced a section on the 20 most powerful Non-Resident Indians (NRIs) and it was both timely and appropriate. In America, President Barack Obama has appointed a number of people of Indian origin to key posts in his administration and the guest list at the high-powered dinner at the White House in honour of Prime Minister Manmohan Singh was evidence of the influence they wield. With India's growing ambition to be a major power, NRIs or Persons of Indian Origin (PIOs) are becoming an increasingly important part of that strategy. Nothing illustrates that more than the role they played in lobbying for the Indo-US nuclear deal, with some key players getting acknowledgement in this year's Padma Bhushan awards. Across the Atlantic, a resident with an Indian passport has been regularly listed as the richest man in Britain, and the annual rich list features any number of PIOs. One has also been appointed Deputy Speaker of the House of Commons, the first Asian to hold the post. They also feature high up the global corporate ladder and are equally prominent in the world's top universities, research institutions and the world of literature. More to the point, they are the most affluent immigrants in almost every country and, numbering over 25 million, represent a dynamic face of Brand India.

L.N. MITTAL

60, Industrialist (1)

Real Steel

Because despite losing \$23 billion last year, equivalent to the GDP of Cameroon, the eighth richest man in the world and the richest individual in Britain has untrammelled access to global leaders in business and politics.

Because ArcelorMittal, the family-owned conglomerate, remains the world's largest steel company, controlling 10 per cent of global steel production.

Because despite the global meltdown and falling steel demand, his personal wealth is \$19.3 billion, which he is investing in an array of acquisitions, from the British football club Queen's Park Rangers to a major stake in Australia's Macarthur Coal, to UK's RAB Capital, shares in Indiabulls and a 35 per cent stake in Uttam Galva Steel.

Because he has pledged \$9 million to set up the Champion's Trust to support 10 Indian athletes with the potential to be world champions.

Because when he threatens to stop work on a project unless fiscal incentives are restored, as he did on the Rs 18,919-crore refinery in Punjab, governments listen.

Did you know His pay cut of 12 per cent reduced his basic salary to \$1.49 million but his 2009 performance bonus added \$2.1 million.

The Next Sage

Because he is tipped to succeed Warren Buffet, the world's richest man and smartest investor, whose Berkshire Hathaway controls an array of assets worth \$109 billion.

Because as president of the company's Reinsurance Division, he specialises in high-risk, high-value reinsurance, has Buffet's unwavering support, and a blank cheque.

Because the Sage of Omaha referred to Jain as "an extraordinary talent" and a "superstar" in his latest annual letter to shareholders.

Did you know The IIT-Harvard graduate bid \$8.2 million for a New York City condominium owned by scam lawyer Marc Dreier.

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AJIT JAIN

59, Business Executive (2)

